



Treasure chambers of Augustus II

△ **Order of the Polish White Eagle** from the collection

The he Grünes Gewölbe (Green Vault) in the Residenzschloss in Dresden, Germany, is home to the largest collection of treasures in Europe. Founded in 1730 by Augustus II (1670–1733) to hold the royal jewel collection, it contains over 3,000 unique treasures. Augustus the Strong, as he was known, opened the doors of the Baroque rooms to the public, thus creating Europe's first public museum.

Among the featured exhibits is the extraordinary tableau of “The Royal Household at Delhi on the Occasion of the Birthday of the Grand Mogul Aurangzeb”. The miniature model features the seventh Mughal Emperor of Hindustan, Emperor Aurangzeb (1658–1707), seated under a canopy and surrounded by 137 enamelled figures of men, animals, and objects of gold, ivory, silver, and jewels. The model originally comprised 5,223 diamonds, 189 rubies, 175 emeralds, 53 pearls, two



cameos, and a sapphire – today, 391 precious stones and pearls are missing. The piece was created by one of Europe's greatest goldsmiths, Johann Melchior Dinglinger, c.1701–08. He was not commissioned to create the piece, but Augustus, who was delighted with the fabulous details, eventually paid him more than he spent constructing his castle at Moritzburg.

The piece embodies European society's fascination with Indian palaces and their riches. The wealth and power of the Mughal Empire reached its zenith under Aurangzeb; in the model he is depicted receiving 32 birthday gifts from the Empire's most powerful princes. These reference some of Dinglinger's other works, along with ancient Egyptian, Chinese, Greek, and Germanic objects and symbols, the significance of which was detailed in an accompanying treatise.



Death drops the curtain even on Emperors

Emperor **Aurangzeb**

Key dates

1658-1959

1650 Aurangzeb becomes the seventh Mughal emperor

1658 Aurangzeb becomes the seventh Mughal emperor

1698 Augustus II appoints Johann Melchior Dinglinger as court jeweller

1700

1701–08 Johann Dinglinger and brothers create the Aurangzeb tableau

1723 The Grünes Gewölbe in Dresden is founded by Augustus II

1723–30 Augustus II creates a Baroque chamber for the treasures at Grünes Gewölbe, including the Aurangzeb model

1750

1900

1925

1930s Artworks from the Grünes Gewölbe are evacuated to Königstein Fortress outside Dresden

1945 The surviving treasures are looted by the Soviet Red Army

1950

1958 The Soviet government returns the pieces to Dresden

1958 Parts of the collection are put on display in the Albertinum modern art museum in Dresden

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